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Most older R&AW agents felt that only three customers—Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi and Narasimha Rao—genuinely appreciated espionage tradecraft. Rao in particular, a senior officer mentioned, was very shrewd in his dealings with the agency. He would listen to important reports narrated by the chief and other officers without uttering a word. At the end of the presentation, his only response was, 'Okay.' This perplexed a newly appointed chief who thought Rao did not like what they were doing or were planning to do because he never interrupted, did not question, and never said that he agreed. 'I told the chief not to worry because the PM agrees with what we are doing. If he had any objection, he would convey it immediately,' said a spy codenamed Madhav Anand. 'Once, when we informed Rao about an impending exchange of nuclear-installation lists with Pakistan to ensure that the Indian government is not attacked from any side, he said, "Okay." On another occasion, the government needed some help from a Middle East country and the PM spoke about it. But this was rare. He just listened to us attentively and meetings ended in half an hour. He never openly expressed his feelings, though we knew he admired our courage. We achieved a great degree of success in the Middle East during Rajiv Gandhi's tenure. The backroom manoeuvring by the R&AW reflected in open diplomacy. We created assets in Egypt, Algeria, Morocco, Tunisia and Iran, and tried to strike a balance between Israel and Palestine. In April 1985, Yasser Arafat was invited to attend a meeting with Rajiv Gandhi despite the reservations of Israel's intelligence agency, Mossad.'

In many ways, the R&AW spies have been lucky too. For instance, they have never had to face interference in tactical